

Book I - The Sagent Creed

Part 4 - The Fibonacci Spiral Through the Generations

Chapter 16 - Art and the Green Knight

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The Orphan

He was born Arthur Charles Farrington on October 12, 1921, in Detroit, Michigan. His father left before he could remember. His mother could not keep him. By the age of nine, he was an orphan.

I have thought about this more than almost anything else in the Clokey story — not the fame, not the legacy, not the green clay figure that became an American icon, but the orphaning. Because everything that followed grew from this wound. Every act of creation Art Clokey ever performed was, in some way, a response to having been abandoned by the people who were supposed to hold him. Everything he built was shelter. Everything he imagined was a world where a small, flexible, green figure could walk into any story and *belong*.

An orphan at nine. Placed in foster care. Moved through the system the way the system moves children — as a problem to be managed, not a soul to be cultivated. And then, a rescue. Joseph Waddell Clokey — a composer, a man of music and gentleness — adopted the boy. Gave him a name. Gave him a home. Gave him the thing the system could not provide: a father.

Art Clokey was made by two forces. The first was abandonment — the knowledge, burned into his childhood, that the world does not owe you belonging. That the people who are supposed to stay can leave. That the structure you depend on can vanish. This knowledge does one of two things to a person: it makes you desperate to belong to any structure that will have you, or it makes you determined to build a structure so real, so true, so rooted in something deeper than convenience, that it cannot abandon you — because you are the one who made it.

Art became the second kind.

The other force was Joseph Clokey — the adoptive father, the composer, the man who showed Art that creation is not commerce. That music exists because beauty exists. That a man can spend his life making something that does not sell, and the making is still worth the life. Joseph did not teach Art to be an artist. Joseph *showed* Art what an artist looked like — and Art spent the rest of his life becoming one.

The Education

He studied at Hartford Art School and Pomona College before arriving at the University of Southern California for film school. There, he found the teacher who gave him the language for what he had always felt.

Slavko Vorkapich was a Serbian filmmaker and montage theorist who understood cinema not as a commercial medium but as a *language* — a language of movement, rhythm, and transformation. Vorkapich taught that film was not about recording reality. Film was about *revealing* reality — showing the dynamics beneath the surface, the forces that move through matter, the aliveness of the physical world.

Under Vorkapich, Art made *Gumbasia* in 1953. A short film. Abstract clay shapes moving to jazz — stretching, compressing, transforming, alive with rhythm. No characters. No story. Just clay *being alive*. Moving the way music moves. Changing the way living things change. Becoming and unbecoming and becoming again.

Gumbasia was a thesis film. It was also a Genesis. The entire Gumby universe — the clay, the transformation, the idea that form is not fixed, that the living thing can change and grow and enter any story — was encoded in those few minutes of abstract movement. The seed was planted in a university film lab, and it carried inside it the code for sixty years of creation.

From *Gumbasia* came the idea of a character. A figure made of the same transformable clay. Green — the color of growth, of chlorophyll, of every living thing that converts light into life. Soft, pliable, capable of stretching into any shape without breaking. A figure that could walk into books — literally enter the stories — and become part of whatever world it found there.

Gumby was born. And with Gumby, Art Clokey found the form that would carry his philosophy for the rest of his life.

The Philosophy

Art Clokey was a man on a spiritual search that never ended.

He started in the Episcopal church — the adopted boy seeking structure, seeking the father, seeking the institution that would not leave. He studied at Hartford Theological Seminary. But the institution could not hold him, because Art was not looking for an institution. He was looking for God — and God, as Art would discover over and over throughout his life, does not live in institutions.

In the 1960s, the counterculture opened doors that the seminary had kept closed. Art explored Buddhism. He sat in meditation. He studied Eastern philosophy — not as an academic exercise but as a man genuinely trying to understand the structure of consciousness, the nature of compassion, the relationship between the inner life and the outer form.

And then he found Sathya Sai Baba — the Indian guru who taught universal love as the foundation of all spiritual practice. *Prema*. The word that would name the studio. The word that would fund every creative decision Art ever made. The word that was the root system beneath the clay.

I want to be careful here, because the tendency of the modern mind is to flatten this journey into a caricature — to call Art a "spiritual seeker" the way the culture calls people "spiritual but not religious," as though the seeking were a phase rather than a discipline. Art's spiritual journey was not dilettantism. It was rigorous. It was costly. It was the organizing principle of his creative life.

He studied at an Episcopal seminary and learned the rigor of systematic theology. He practiced Buddhist meditation and learned the discipline of inner silence. He followed Sai Baba and learned the power of universal love as a structural principle. And he poured all of it — every tradition, every practice, every hard-won insight — into the clay.

Davey and Goliath was explicitly Christian — a clay-animated series produced for the Lutheran Church in America, telling stories of faith, conscience, and moral courage. Gumby was implicitly spiritual — a green figure who could enter any story, who was soft enough to change but strong enough to return to his own shape, whose enemies were rigid and geometric and incapable of imagination.

The man was not confused. The man was comprehensive. He drew from every well because he was building something that was meant to hold water from all of them. *Premavision* was not a denomination. It was a wellspring — and the water came from everywhere that water comes from, because water does not respect the boundaries that institutions draw around their sources.

The Green Knight

In the medieval poem *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, a massive green figure rides into King Arthur's court on New Year's Day and issues a challenge. He offers any knight the chance to strike him with his own axe — on the condition that the knight must find him one year later and receive the same blow.

Sir Gawain accepts. He cuts off the Green Knight's head. The Green Knight picks up his head, reminds Gawain of the bargain, and rides away.

The Green Knight is a test. He is not an enemy in the conventional sense — he does not seek to conquer Camelot or overthrow Arthur. He seeks to *test the integrity* of the court. He rides in with an impossible challenge and watches to see who has the courage to accept it and the honor to fulfill it. The entire poem is about one question: will the knight keep his word, even when it costs him everything?

Art Clokey was the Green Knight of children's entertainment.

He rode into the industry with something impossible — a green clay figure in a world of hand-drawn animation. A character built on spiritual principles in an industry built on commercial ones. A studio named after a Sanskrit word for love in a marketplace that spoke only the language of profit.

And he issued a challenge. Not in words — in *being*. The challenge was: *can you deal with someone who will not sell? Can your industry accommodate a creator who maintains full ownership, full control, full alignment between the vision and the product? Can you work with a man whose bottom line is not money but meaning?*

The industry could not. Not because Art was difficult — by all accounts, he was generous, warm, eccentric in the way that genuinely creative people are eccentric. But because the industry's architecture is the sword's architecture. Consolidation. Acquisition. The conversion of art into intellectual property and intellectual property into revenue. The industry does not know what to do with a creator who will not convert. The industry's entire machinery runs on the assumption that everything is for sale — and when it encounters something that is not, the machinery grinds and stalls and eventually moves on to the next acquisition.

Art held. For sixty years, he held. Through the original Gumby series in the 1950s. Through the lean years. Through the revival in the 1980s — *The Gumby Show* returned, and Art directed new episodes in his sixties, still making clay move, still telling stories about a green figure who could enter any book. Through the merchandising boom when Gumby became a pop culture icon and the offers to sell must have been staggering. Through the quiet years at the end, when the culture had moved on to digital animation and clay was considered quaint.

He held.

He held the way a root holds the soil — not by grasping, but by going deeper. He did not fight the industry. He did not protest the system. He did not write manifestos or launch campaigns or make himself a symbol of resistance. He simply continued to create, on his own terms, from his own studio, funded by his own vision, aligned with the word he had chosen: *Prema*.

The Green Knight does not fight the court. The Green Knight *tests* the court. And if the court fails the test, the Green Knight does not burn Camelot to the ground. He simply reveals — by his presence, by his persistence, by his refusal to play by the court's rules — that the court's integrity was always thinner than it claimed.

Art Clokey revealed, by his life, that the entertainment industry has no integrity. Not because every person in it is corrupt, but because the *structure* does not reward integrity. The structure rewards sale.

The structure rewards conversion. The structure rewards the transformation of the living thing into the dead product. And a man who refuses to convert — who holds the living thing alive for sixty years, who dies at eighty-eight still owning what he created, still aligned with the word he spoke at the beginning — that man is a standing rebuke to the entire architecture.

January 8, 2010

Art Clokey died on January 8, 2010, at his home in Clovis, California. He was eighty-eight years old.

He died owning Gumby. He died owning Premavision. He died with the rights intact, the vision uncompromised, the word still spoken. Sixty years of creation, and not one frame sold to someone who did not understand what it meant.

I was five years old. I do not remember his death the way my father remembered it — I was too young to understand what had been lost. But I understand now. I understand that what died on January 8, 2010, was not just a man. It was a proof of concept. It was the living evidence that a human being could hold something pure for an entire lifetime without selling it. That the seed-over-sword principle was not just philosophy — it was *possible*. One man had done it. One man had proved it could be done.

The orphan boy who was abandoned at nine built a world of imagination, named it after universal love, held it for six decades, and left it to his family with the soul still intact. He did not just create a character. He proved that a man could hold something pure his entire life without selling it.

The Green Knight tested the industry and the industry failed. But the Green Knight was never defeated. He rode back out the way he rode in — green, alive, impossible — and the court was left to reckon with what it had been shown.

Art Clokey was the green figure in a world of blocks. Soft where the industry was hard. Alive where the industry was mechanical. Transformable where the industry was rigid. He walked into the story of American entertainment and became part of it without becoming *of* it. He entered the book without losing himself in the book.

And when he left, the book was different. The story had been changed. Not by force — by *presence*. By sixty years of being the green thing in a yellow world. By proving that the seed outlasts the sword, that love outlasts commerce, that the man who will not sell is the man the industry cannot forget.

Art Clokey. Born Arthur Charles Farrington. Orphaned at nine. Adopted by a composer. Educated by a visionary. Transformed by love. Green Knight of children's entertainment.

He held the seed for sixty years and never let the sword touch it.

Premavision.

The vision of universal love.

The root that holds.

The Living Age Trilogy